INTERVIEW PACK · PORTFOLIO PROJECT 02

Ledgerline Agentic Banking Lakehouse

A Bronze → Silver → Gold Delta Lake pipeline on Apache Spark with data-quality expectations, reconciliation controls, SCD Type 2 history, Change Data Feed, time travel and AML alert candidates. On top: three AI agents that investigate AML alerts, find the root cause of a blocked load and answer business questions, with read-only tools, an audit trail and human approval. Built to run locally, in CI and on Databricks.

18,517 source records landed	**3** AI agents with human approval	**58** automated tests
1 truncated delivery blocked at Bronze	**8 / 8** AML cases decided correctly (offline planner)	**16 of 17** controls passed, 1 tripped as designed

Code: https://github.com/nipunrg1990rocks-dev/banking-ai-portfolio/tree/main/projects/p2_lakehouse
Author: Nipun Gupta · October 2026

Independent project developed with AI-assisted development tools. All data is synthetic and describes a fictional bank. Not affiliated with any employer or real financial institution. The full pipeline was run on Databricks Free Edition on 26 October 2026 with results identical to the local run of that data version (Appendix C). Agent scores shown are from the offline planner (no LLM). The agents were also run on Databricks with a free Foundation Model, as reported by the author, but that run's model and scores were not captured. The scheduled Databricks job, the column masks and the hosted demo URL were not yet verified when this pack was produced.

> How to describe it: "I developed this independent project using AI-assisted development tools. I defined the data model, the data-quality rules and the controls from my banking experience. I directed the AI tools that wrote the code, reviewed what they produced, and tested and validated the results." Do not attribute it to any employer. Do not claim you hand-wrote the code.

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1. The 60-second executive summary

"In a bank, bad data isn't an IT problem. It's a misstated report, a missed AML alert, or a payment counted twice. I built a lakehouse for a fictional bank that takes raw core-banking files and turns them into tables that risk and financial-crime teams can trust. It uses a **Bronze, Silver, Gold** design on **Apache Spark and Delta Lake**. Bronze keeps exactly what the source sent. Silver validates it against 18 data-quality rules, quarantines the bad records with the reason, keeps **full history of customer risk-rating changes**, and makes sure a re-sent payment can never be counted twice. Gold produces **AML alert candidates**, a customer 360 view and KPIs. Like a finance reconciliation, every step must balance: the run **stops** if Bronze doesn't match the source's control totals, or if any record is unaccounted for. I planted known defects and suspicious patterns in the synthetic data. The pipeline found **every one and nothing else**, and 58 automated tests prove it on every code change. On top of the data, **three AI agents** do analyst work. One investigates each AML alert and writes a scored, evidence-cited case. One finds the root cause when a load is blocked and drafts the ticket. One answers business questions in plain English with SQL. They only read data through tools, every step is audited, and a person approves what they propose. I score them against the same answer key. The same code runs on my laptop, in CI and on Databricks."

2. Business problem and banking use case

- **Users:** data engineering, finance and regulatory reporting, AML/financial-crime operations, and risk MI teams.
- **Pain:** source extracts arrive with missing or malformed values, duplicates and late re-sends. Reports built on them are silently wrong. Customer attributes change, such as a KYC risk rating, and overwriting them destroys the history auditors need. Reconciliation is often manual spreadsheet work.
- **What the lakehouse gives them:**
  - one trusted copy of each entity with documented quality
  - proof that every source record is accounted for
  - point-in-time history
  - business-ready tables for AML triage and management reporting
- **Regulatory angle:** banking data principles (accuracy, completeness, timeliness, adaptability, as in BCBS 239), auditability, data minimisation for privacy, and human review of AML alerts.
- **Why medallion?** Separating raw, validated and business layers means a bug in Gold never forces a reload from source. A data-quality issue can be traced back to the exact file and row.

3. Key numbers from the committed run

Measure	Value
Source records landed (2 batches + reference data)	18,517
Silver transactions	16,648
Duplicates removed / records quarantined	33 / 25

Measure	Value
DQ checks evaluated / blocking controls passed	53 / 16 of 17 (the 17th blocked the planted truncated delivery, as designed)
AML alert candidates	8 (3 structuring, 3 high-risk jurisdiction, 2 rapid movement). 7 genuine, 1 planted false positive (a corporate payroll cycle)
SCD2 customer changes captured / unchanged re-sends ignored	40 / 5
Late re-sent transactions not double-counted	10
Pipeline time on one machine	about 100 seconds
Automated tests (Project 02) / whole repo	58 / 106
Agent evaluation, offline planner (no LLM)	AML 8/8 cases fully correct, incident 1/1, questions 6/6
Agent evaluation, Claude	Not yet run (needs API key and cost approval)

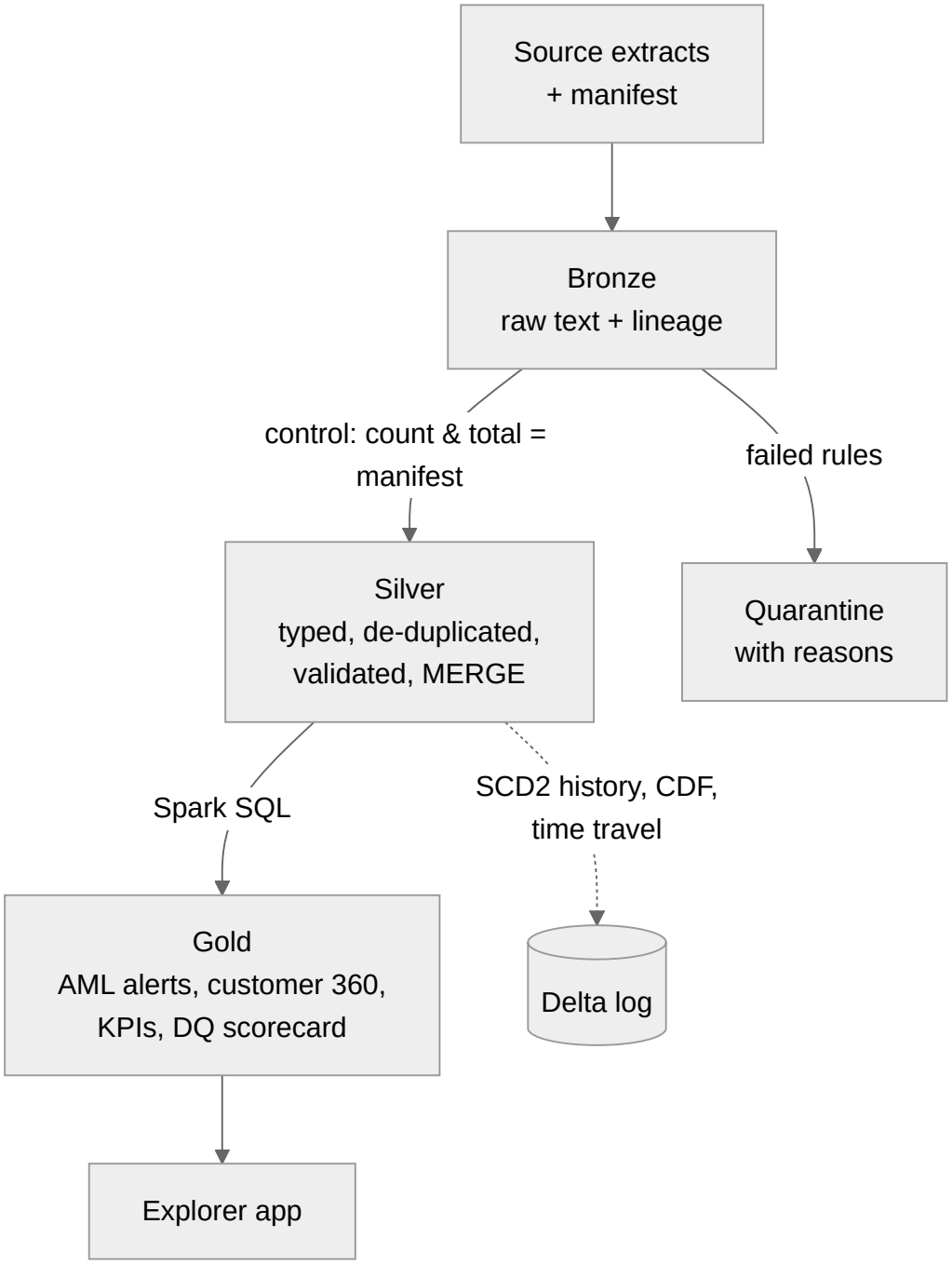
4. What each technology does (plain English, then technical)

Technology	Plain English	In this project
Apache Spark / PySpark	An engine that processes big tables in parallel across many machines	Silver logic in the DataFrame API (`silver.py`). Locally `local[2]`; on Databricks, serverless compute
Spark SQL	SQL that runs on Spark	Every Gold table is one `.sql` file in `lakehouse/sql/gold/`
Delta Lake	Turns files in storage into reliable database tables	ACID transactions, MERGE, time travel, Change Data Feed, schema enforcement, OPTIMIZE
Medallion architecture	Raw → cleaned → business-ready layers	Bronze (`bronze.py`), Silver (`silver.py`), Gold (`gold.py`)
MERGE (upsert)	"Insert if new, update if changed" in one atomic step	SCD2 customers, upsert accounts, insert-only transactions
SCD Type 2	Keep every version of a record with its valid dates	`effective_from`, `effective_to`, `is_current`, and a `record_hash` to spot real changes
Data-quality expectations	Rules every record must pass, with what to do if it fails	`dq.py`: SQL expressions with warn, drop or fail, in the same style as Databricks Lakeflow expectations
Quarantine	A holding pen for bad records, with the reason	`silver.*_quarantine` keeps raw values and `_dq_failed_rules`
Reconciliation controls	Proof that totals match, like a finance rec	Manifest count and amount checks, the Bronze = outcomes check, Gold = Silver checks
Unity Catalog	Databricks' governance layer: catalog.schema.table, permissions, lineage	Tables at `workspace.ledgerline_<layer>`, a landing volume, tags and column masks
Lakeflow Jobs	Databricks' scheduler for multi-step pipelines	`01_create_job.py` builds a 6-task DAG with retries
Time travel	Read a table as it was at an earlier version	`VERSION AS OF 0` returns the September state
Change Data Feed	A log of row-level inserts and updates	Shows exactly what batch 2 changed in customers and accounts
OPTIMIZE / Z-ORDER	Tidy small files and sort data so queries skip what they don't need	Run on Silver transactions and customers after Gold

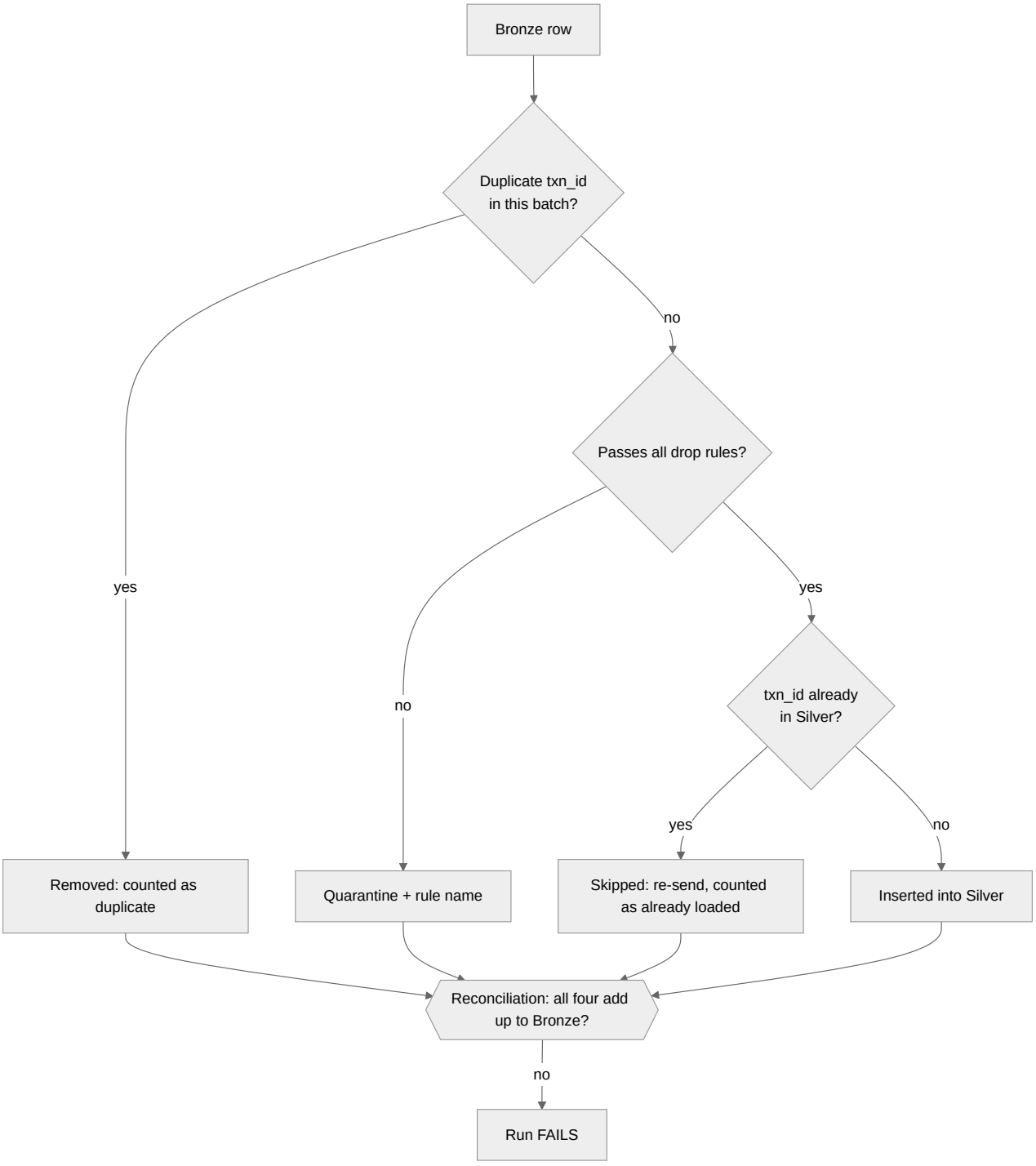
Technology	Plain English	In this project
AI agents (tool use)	A model that decides which tool to call next, reads the result and keeps going until it can answer	`agents/` : 14 read-only tools, strict submit schemas, step limits, audit log
Claude (Anthropic API)	The LLM that powers the agents in live mode	Manual tool-use loop with adaptive thinking and prompt caching (`brains.py`); runs are recorded and replayed
Offline planner	A fixed checklist in code that uses the same tools, no AI	Keeps the app free and gives the evaluation a baseline; labelled in the app
Streamlit	Python framework for web apps	Mission Control, three agent tabs, a lakehouse explorer and How it works
DuckDB	A tiny in-process SQL engine	Powers the app's read-only SQL console, locked against file access
pytest / Playwright / GitHub Actions	Automated tests, a robot browser, CI	58 tests that run the real pipeline and the agents, a 12-step browser test, and CI on every push

5. Diagrams

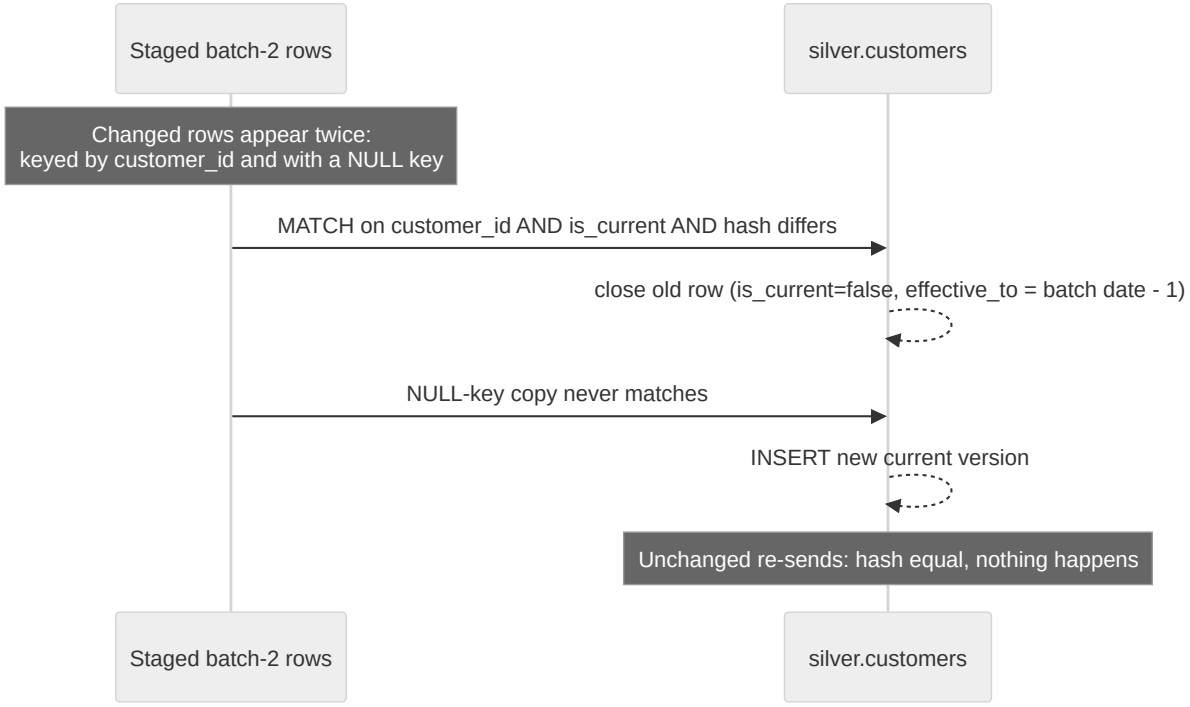
5.1 Medallion data flow



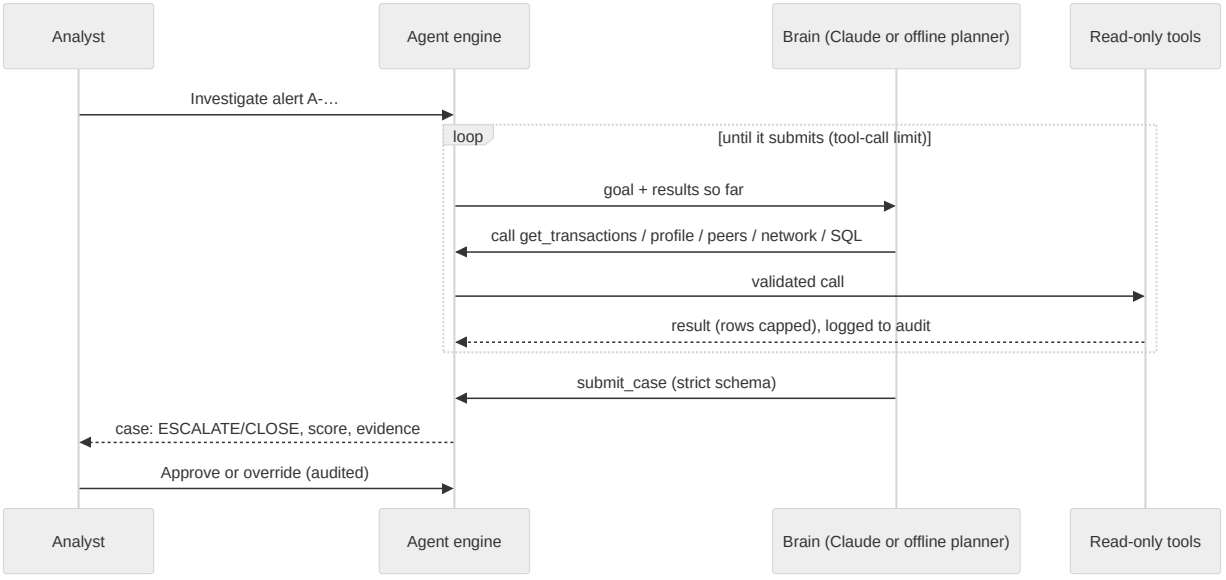
5.2 What happens to one Bronze transaction



5.3 SCD Type 2 MERGE



5.4 How an agent investigates an alert



The full component diagram, data model and controls are in Appendix A.

6. Three-minute demo script

Time	Do	Say
0:00	Open the app, Mission Control	"This is a lakehouse for a fictional bank, all synthetic, with AI agents on top. Overnight, two batches went Bronze to Silver to Gold on Spark and Delta Lake. A third delivery was blocked, and there are 8 AML alerts waiting."

Time	Do	Say
0:20	Point at the red BLOCKED stage	"A transactions file arrived cut off. The manifest promised 3,150 rows; the Bronze control stopped it, so nothing downstream changed."
0:35	Data Steward tab, Dispatch	"Instead of an engineer digging through logs, the Data Steward agent checks the pipeline audit, then the file itself: bytes, checksum, the last line. It finds a truncated file, 315 rows missing, and drafts the ticket. I approve it."
1:15	AML Investigator tab, pick the payroll alert, Dispatch	"Now an alert. Watch the trace: it pulls the transactions, the customer profile, 90 days of behaviour, peers and the counterparty network. Here it finds a monthly payroll cycle that went just over the threshold, and recommends CLOSE with a score and cited evidence. It recommends; I decide."
2:00	Run on all alerts and score	"I don't trust an agent I can't measure. This scores every case against the answer key planted in the data: right decision, trigger transactions cited, no invented ids."
2:25	Ask Ledgerline, click a suggested question	"Business users can ask in plain English. It writes the SQL, runs it read-only and draws the chart."
2:45	Close on How it works	"Same code on Databricks with Unity Catalog. 58 tests. And this page says clearly what is verified and what isn't."

7. Ten-minute demo script

0. **(1.5 min) Agents.** Start in Mission Control. Run the Data Steward on the incident, then the AML Investigator on one genuine alert and on the payroll false positive. Show the trace, the approval buttons and the audit trail. Run the scorecard. Say which brain is running (recorded Claude, or the offline planner) and what that means.
1. **(1 min) Problem framing.** Bad data in banks causes misreporting, missed alerts and double counting. Name the BCBS 239 principles. Explain why history and reconciliation matter.
2. **(1.5 min) Architecture.** Use the How it works tab and the lineage graph. Walk through landing (with a manifest, as real source systems send), Bronze, Silver and Gold. Explain the `TableStore` idea: the same code runs locally and on Databricks.
3. **(1.5 min) Reconciliation and controls.** Show the batch equations. Then show the failure path for real: delivery 20261014 promised 3,150 rows and arrived truncated, so Bronze failed and nothing downstream changed. Automated tests prove this.
4. **(1.5 min) Data quality.** Show the scorecard, quarantine and warn rules. Explain the fail-safe rule: an invalid KYC rating becomes HIGH rather than being dropped, because losing a customer from monitoring is worse than over-monitoring.
5. **(1.5 min) AML.** Cover the three rules and their SQL (expand the SQL panel), priority logic, the human review status, and data minimisation in Gold.
6. **(1 min) History.** Show SCD2 before and after, the as-of join used in segment KPIs, and the Change Data Feed.
7. **(1 min) Delta internals.** Cover history, MERGE metrics, time travel, OPTIMIZE and Z-ORDER, and schema enforcement.
8. **(0.5 min) SQL console.** Run "cash deposits just under 10,000". Mention that the console is sandboxed.
9. **(0.5 min) Testing and honesty.** 58 tests compare results to the generator's answer key. CI runs the pipeline. Then state what isn't verified yet.

8. Code walkthrough (where things are)

File	What it does	Talking point
`lakehouse/synthetic.py`	Generates customers, accounts and transactions, plants defects and AML scenarios, writes a manifest	"Random noise is capped below every AML threshold, so only planted scenarios can alert. That makes the test exact."
`lakehouse/store.py`	`get_spark()`, `LakehouseConfig`, `TableStore`	"One switch between local Delta paths and Unity Catalog names."
`lakehouse/bronze.py`	Reads CSV/JSON as strings, adds lineage, makes the load idempotent, runs the manifest controls	"`_metadata.file_path` gives row-level lineage for free."
`lakehouse/dq.py`	`Rule`, `apply_expectations`, `control_check`, and the rule lists	"One pass tags each row with an array of failed rule names. A NULL result counts as a failure."
`lakehouse/silver.py`	Typing, de-duplication, PII protection, FX, SCD2/upsert/insert-only MERGEs, reconciliation	"The SCD2 MERGE uses the staged-union pattern with a NULL merge key."
`lakehouse/sql/gold/*.sql`	Five Gold tables	"Placeholders like `${silver.transactions}` are resolved per environment."
`lakehouse/pipeline.py`	Orchestration, audit logging, OPTIMIZE	"Every step writes to `audit.pipeline_steps` and `audit.dq_results`."
`lakehouse/snapshot.py`	Exports a run for the app	"Records run id, engine and versions, so the app never overstates what it shows."
`databricks/*.py`	Run-all notebook, job creation with the Databricks SDK, governance SQL	"The notebook authenticates as the user; no tokens anywhere."
`explorer.py`, `app.py`	App data layer and UI	"DuckDB with external access disabled and the configuration locked."
`agents/tools.py`	The 14 read-only tools and 3 submit tools, with strict JSON schemas	"The agent can only do what a tool allows, and every tool only reads."
`agents/engine.py`	The loop: tool-call limit, audit, error handling, result truncation	"Every step is audited in a hash-chained log."
`agents/brains.py`	Claude (tool use, adaptive thinking, caching) and the offline planner	"Same tools, same engine; only the decision-maker changes."
`agents/specs.py`	System prompts, house rules and the offline playbooks	"House rules: cite evidence, never invent ids, recommend don't decide."
`agents/evals.py`, `run_agents.py`	Scores agents against the answer key; records Claude runs for replay	"I measure the agent, I don't just demo it."
`tests/`	Generator, controls, end-to-end pipeline, snapshot, app and agent tests	"The tests compare against an answer key, not just 'it ran'."

9. Interview questions and answers

Architecture and design

1. **Why Bronze, Silver and Gold instead of loading straight into reporting tables?** Separation of concerns and recoverability. Bronze is an immutable record of what the source sent. If Silver logic has a bug, I fix it and rebuild from Bronze without asking the source to resend. Gold can change for new business needs without touching validation logic. *Follow-up: isn't three copies wasteful?* Storage is cheap compared with a misstatement. Bronze can also have a shorter retention period and stricter access.

2. **Why keep every Bronze column as a string?** So ingestion never fails or silently loses data because of a bad value. If `amount` arrives as "abc", Bronze stores "abc". Silver's `try_cast` turns it into NULL and the `amount_present` rule quarantines it, with the raw value kept for the data steward.

3. **What is the `TableStore` and why does it matter?** It's the one class that maps (layer, table) to either a local Delta path or a Unity Catalog name. Because of it, the PySpark and SQL are identical in CI and on Databricks. What I test is what I deploy.

4. **How is the pipeline orchestrated?** Locally, `Pipeline.run_all()` runs land, reference, then Bronze and Silver for each batch, then Gold, then OPTIMIZE. On Databricks, a Lakeflow Jobs DAG runs the same steps as separate tasks with dependencies and retries, sharing one `run_id`. *Follow-up: why split into tasks?* Retries happen per step, failures are easier to see, and a failed Gold step doesn't re-ingest.

5. **How would this change for streaming?** Bronze would use Auto Loader (`cloudFiles`) to discover new files incrementally, with checkpointing. Silver's MERGE logic would run in `foreachBatch`, and an `availableNow` trigger keeps it cost-efficient. The DQ rules could move to Lakeflow Declarative Pipelines expectations, which map one-to-one onto my warn/drop/fail actions.

Data quality and controls

6. **How do your data-quality rules work?** Each rule is a SQL boolean expression plus an action. In one pass, every row gets an array of the rule names it failed. Rows failing a drop rule go to quarantine, warn rules only flag the row, and fail rules stop the run. Metrics per rule are written to `audit.dq_results`, which feeds the Gold scorecard.

7. **Why does a NULL count as a failure?** In SQL, `amount > 0` is NULL when the amount is missing, and a naive filter would quietly let it through or drop it without counting. I wrap every rule in `coalesce(expr, false)`, so missing data is always counted and explained.

8. **What's the difference between your DQ rules and your controls?** Rules judge individual records. Controls judge the whole load: did we receive what the source said it sent, and is every record accounted for? Controls are blocking because a control failure means the numbers can't be trusted at all.

9. **Walk me through the reconciliation.** For each batch: Bronze rows = duplicates removed + quarantined + already loaded + inserted. For batch 1 that's 13,539 = 25 + 19 + 0 + 13,495. Gold then has to add back to Silver in both count and USD value. If any equation breaks, the step is logged FAILED and the run stops.

10. **Why default an invalid KYC risk rating to HIGH instead of quarantining the customer?** Quarantining the customer would orphan their accounts and transactions, which drops them out of AML monitoring. That's the worst outcome. Treating the rating as HIGH until a data steward fixes it is fail-safe: over-monitoring is recoverable, under-monitoring isn't. I found this in testing: one bad rating cascaded into 2 quarantined accounts and 26 quarantined transactions across both batches.

11. **How do you know the pipeline catches the right records and not just some records?** The generator keeps an answer key of every planted defect, duplicate, re-send, SCD2 change and AML scenario. Tests assert that the quarantine per rule equals the answer key exactly, and that the alerts per rule equal the planted customers exactly.

12. **What happens to quarantined data?** It stays in `*_quarantine` with the raw values, batch id and failed rules, ready for a data steward. It is replaced per batch on re-runs, so it never duplicates. In production I'd add a remediation workflow and ageing metrics, which feeds naturally into Project 04's DQ dashboard.

Delta Lake

13. **What does Delta Lake add on top of Parquet files?** A transaction log. That gives ACID commits, MERGE/UPDATE/DELETE, schema enforcement, time travel, Change Data Feed and file-layout optimisation. Plain Parquet has none of these, so two writers or a failed job can leave a table half-written.

14. **Explain your transaction MERGE.** `MERGE INTO silver.transactions t USING batch s ON t.txn_id = s.txn_id WHEN NOT MATCHED THEN INSERT *`. Because there's no WHEN MATCHED clause, an existing transaction is never touched. In batch 2, ten September transactions were re-sent; the MERGE metrics show 3,153 inserted, and the 10 re-sends were correctly skipped.

15. **Explain your SCD Type 2 MERGE.** I stage the batch twice for changed customers: once keyed by `customer_id` and once with a NULL key. Matching rows whose hash differs get closed: `is_current = false` and `effective_to` set to the day before. The NULL-key copy can't match, so it's inserted as the new current version. New customers are inserted directly. Unchanged re-sends have the same hash, so nothing happens. All of this is one atomic commit.

16. **Why use a hash for change detection?** Comparing five attributes with null-safe logic is error-prone. A SHA-256 of the tracked attributes makes "did anything change?" a single comparison. Only tracked attributes go into the hash, so a change to, say, an e-mail typo doesn't create a new risk-history version.

17. **How does time travel help a bank?** Reproducibility. If a regulator asks why a report showed X on a given date, I can query the table `VERSION AS OF` that run and get identical results. It also enables rollback after a bad load with `RESTORE`.

18. **What is Change Data Feed and where would you use it?** It records row-level inserts and updates (with before and after images) per commit. Here it shows exactly which customers changed in batch 2. At scale, Gold would read only those changes instead of recomputing everything.

19. **What do OPTIMIZE and Z-ORDER do?** OPTIMIZE compacts many small files into fewer large ones. Z-ORDER co-locates rows with similar `customer_id` and `txn_date`, so file-level statistics let queries skip most files. Row counts don't change, only the layout. On newer Databricks runtimes I'd consider liquid clustering instead.

20. **What is schema enforcement? Show me it working.** Delta rejects a write whose schema doesn't match the table. A test appends a DataFrame where `amount_usd` is a string, and the write fails. Schema changes have to be deliberate (`mergeSchema`), not accidental.

Spark

21. **Why use `try_cast` instead of `cast`?** Spark 4 runs in ANSI mode, so `cast('' AS decimal)` throws and kills the job. `try_cast` returns NULL, and the DQ rules then quarantine the row with a reason. One bad record shouldn't stop 13,000 good ones. I hit exactly this error during the build.

22. **How do you de-duplicate?** A window `row_number()` partitioned by the business key, ordered by `_ingested_at` descending, keeping row 1. That handles exact re-sends within a batch. Re-sends across batches are handled by the insert-only MERGE.

23. **Why did you avoid `cache()` on Databricks?** Serverless compute doesn't support the caching APIs. Locally I cache the tagged DataFrame because it's used for both metrics and the split. On Databricks the code skips that line. It's a small example of designing for the target platform.

24. **How do you convert currencies?** I join each transaction to the daily FX table on (transaction date, currency) and compute `round(amount * usd_rate, 2)`. A missing rate is a drop rule, because a wrong USD amount is worse than a missing one. A test recomputes every converted amount independently.

25. **How would this scale to billions of rows?** Partition or cluster Silver by date. Make Bronze incremental with Auto Loader, make Gold incremental from the Change Data Feed, and avoid driver-side `count()` calls by reading MERGE metrics from the Delta log, which I already do for inserts. Run on autoscaling job compute and monitor skew in joins (for example, a few huge corporate customers).

Databricks and governance

26. **What does Unity Catalog give you here?** A three-level namespace (`workspace.ledgerline_silver.customers`), centralised permissions, automatic table-level lineage from the pipeline's reads and writes, tags for classification, and column masks. The governance notebook hides customer names from anyone outside a KYC analyst group.

27. **How do the notebooks find your Python code?** The repo is cloned as a Git folder. The notebook adds the project folder to `sys.path` and imports the same `lakehouse` package the tests use. No code is copied into notebooks.

28. **How does the job authenticate? Where are the secrets?** There are none. `WorkspaceClient()` inside a notebook uses the signed-in user's identity. In production I'd run jobs as a service principal with least privilege, and keep any external credentials in Databricks secret scopes.

29. **What would you monitor in production?** Step duration and status from `audit.pipeline_steps`, DQ pass rates and trends from `dq_results`, quarantine ageing, reconciliation failures, alert volumes per rule, and freshness (business date vs load time). Alert on any control failure.

AML and business

30. **Explain your three AML rules.** *Structuring:* three or more cash deposits between 9,000 and 9,999.99 USD on the same day. *High-risk jurisdiction:* wires of 10,000 USD or more with a HIGH-tier country. *Rapid movement:* an inbound wire of 50,000 or more with at least 90% wired out within 48 hours. Thresholds are illustrative.

31. **Why are alerts "candidates" and not decisions?** Rules produce false positives, and filing or closing an AML case is a regulated judgement. Every alert starts as PENDING_REVIEW for a human investigator, with its rationale and transaction ids. Project 03 builds that human-in-the-loop workflow.

32. **How did you prevent false positives in your test data?** The generator caps random amounts below every threshold (in USD terms, after FX), so only planted scenarios can trigger an alert. That makes "found exactly these alerts, no extras" a meaningful test, not luck. I then planted one deliberate false positive: a company's monthly payroll that crossed the rapid-movement threshold in October. The rule should fire, and the AML agent should close it after checking the history.

33. **How do you protect personal data?** By layer. Bronze is a restricted evidence copy. Silver hashes the e-mail and masks the phone. Gold has no names, contact details or full date of birth (only birth year). Unity Catalog column masks protect names. Everything is synthetic anyway, and high-risk countries are fictional codes.

34. **Why does segment reporting use an "as-of" join?** A customer who moved from Retail to Premier in October should count as Retail for September. Joining transactions to the customer version whose effective dates cover the transaction date gets this right. A control proves every transaction finds exactly one version.

Testing, delivery and your role

35. **How did you test it?** 58 automated tests. Generator tests check reproducibility and manifest accuracy. Unit tests cover the DQ engine and blocking controls (including a tampered manifest that must fail). End-to-end tests run both batches through real Spark and Delta and compare against the answer key. Other tests cover idempotent re-runs, time travel, the Change Data Feed, schema enforcement, snapshot reproducibility and the SQL console sandbox. Agent tests use a fake Claude client to prove the loop recovers from a SQL error and stops at the step limit, and run the agents on a live local Spark lakehouse. A 12-step Playwright browser test clicks through the app, including dispatching each agent. CI installs Java and runs the pipeline on every push.

36. **What does "idempotent" mean here and how do you prove it?** Running the same batch twice leaves everything unchanged. Bronze skips a batch it already holds, the MERGEs don't re-insert, and quarantine is replaced per batch. A test re-runs batch 2 and asserts every table count is identical.

37. **What's AI-generated and what's yours?** The code was written by AI tools under my direction. I defined the use case, the entities, the defects and AML scenarios to plant, the controls (reconciliation to manifest, fail-safe risk rating), and the acceptance criteria (exact match to the answer key, idempotency). I reviewed outputs, ran and checked the tests and app, and made the design calls, for example quarantine vs fail-safe and the snapshot approach for hosting.

38. **What doesn't work yet, or what would you do next?** The run-all notebook has run on Databricks Free Edition with identical results, but I haven't yet run the scheduled job or applied the column masks there. The hosted app shows a snapshot rather than live Spark. Claude has not yet been evaluated with a real key; until then the scores shown are the offline planner's, and the app says so. Next steps: Auto Loader ingestion, incremental Gold from the Change Data Feed, Lakeflow Declarative Pipelines expectations, and a DQ trends dashboard (Project 04).

AI agents

39. **What makes this "agentic" rather than a chatbot?** The agent is given a goal, not a script. It chooses which tool to call next based on what the last result showed, recovers from errors, and stops only when it can submit a structured result. The AML agent might check peers first or the counterparty network first, depending on the alert.

40. **Why tools instead of giving the model the data?** Control and auditability. The model never touches tables directly. Every tool is read-only, validates its inputs, caps its output and is logged. That is the same least-privilege principle you'd apply to a human analyst's database access.

41. **How do you stop an agent from making things up?** Four ways. House rules in the prompt require citing transaction ids. The submit tool has a strict schema, so the output is structured. The evaluation checks every cited id exists in Silver. And a person approves before anything is acted on.

42. **How do you evaluate an agent?** Against the answer key the generator planted. For AML: right decision, trigger transactions cited, no invented ids, risk score consistent with the decision, no contact data in the narrative. For the incident: correct root cause and exact row counts. For questions: the agent's SQL must return the same result as a reference query.

43. **Why is there an offline planner?** Three reasons. The public app shouldn't need a paid key, it gives the evaluation a baseline, and it proves the tools and engine are independent of the model. It is clearly labelled as not AI. With Claude, the agent decides its own steps and writes its own narrative.

44. **What did the payroll false positive teach you?** A rule-based alert can be technically correct and still not suspicious. The rapid-movement rule fires because 52,400 came in and 97% went out again within 48 hours. Context clears it: a corporate customer, the same counterparties every month, and last month's cycle just under the threshold. That's exactly the judgement an investigator makes, and why the agent recommends rather than decides.

45. **How do you control LLM cost?** Prompt caching on the growing conversation, a tool-call limit per agent, results truncated before they go back to the model, a dollar cap in the recording script, and replaying recorded runs in the public app instead of calling the API per visitor.

46. **How would you deploy this in a bank?** Run the agents as a scheduled Databricks job over Unity Catalog tables (`03_ai_agents` already writes case reports and steps to Delta). Use a service principal with read-only grants and the model key in a secret scope. Route cases to the case-management queue as PENDING_HUMAN_REVIEW, and get model-risk sign-off with the evaluation as evidence.

10. Failure cases you can demonstrate or explain

Scenario	What happens	Evidence
Source says 13,538 rows, 13,537 arrive	Bronze control fails, step logged FAILED, run stops	`test_manifest_mismatch_blocks_bronze_and_is_logged`
Truncated delivery 20261014	Blocked at Bronze; Silver and Gold versions unchanged; Data Steward finds TRUNCATED_FILE, 315 rows missing	Mission Control, Data Steward tab, incident tests
Payroll cycle trips RAPID_MOVEMENT	AML agent recommends CLOSE with evidence	AML Investigator tab, scorecard
Agent writes bad SQL	Error goes back to the model, which corrects it	`test_agents.py` (fake Claude client)
Malformed amount or timestamp	`try_cast` gives NULL, record quarantined with rule name	Quarantine explorer, `test_quarantine_catches_exactly_the_planted_defects`
Batch re-run after a crash	Nothing duplicated	`test_rerunning_a_batch_changes_nothing`
Payment re-sent a week later	Skipped by insert-only MERGE	`test_silver_transactions_are_unique_and_resends_not_double_counted`
Upstream schema drift	Delta rejects the write	`test_schema_enforcement_rejects_a_bad_append`

Scenario	What happens	Evidence
SQL console abuse (file read, DROP, COPY)	Blocked	`test_console_blocks_writes_and_file_access`

11. Resume bullets (accurate and independent)

- Designed and delivered (with AI-assisted development) a Databricks-style medallion lakehouse on Apache Spark 4 and Delta Lake for a synthetic bank. It processes 18.5k source records across two batches through Bronze, Silver and Gold, with 18 declarative data-quality rules and 17 blocking reconciliation controls.
- Implemented SCD Type 2 customer history, idempotent insert-only MERGEs that prevent double-counting of re-sent payments, Change Data Feed and time travel. The pipeline is validated by 58 automated tests that match an answer key of planted defects and AML scenarios exactly.
- Built rule-based AML alert candidates (structuring, high-risk jurisdiction, rapid movement) for human review, plus a Streamlit explorer with lineage, reconciliation, alert drill-down and a sandboxed SQL console. Packaged Unity Catalog governance and a Lakeflow Jobs DAG for Databricks.
- Built three AI agents on the lakehouse (AML investigation, data-incident root cause, natural-language analytics) using LLM tool use with read-only tools, a hash-chained audit trail and human approval, evaluated against a planted answer key.
- Ran the same pipeline on Databricks Free Edition (serverless Spark, Unity Catalog), with row counts identical to the local and CI runs.

12. Your role (say this plainly)

"I acted as product owner, data architect and test lead. I wrote the requirements: what a bank needs from this data, which defects are realistic, which controls a reviewer would expect, and how alerts must stay human-reviewed. I directed AI coding tools to implement them, reviewed the code and outputs, and insisted on tests that prove exact results. I validated the app myself and decided the trade-offs, for example that an invalid risk rating should default to HIGH rather than drop the customer. I also designed how the AI agents should behave: what tools an investigator needs, what they must never do, and how to prove they are right. I can walk through every module and explain every design choice."

13. Certification tie-in (Databricks Data Engineer Associate)

This project exercises these exam topics:

- medallion architecture
- Delta Lake (MERGE, time travel, OPTIMIZE/Z-ORDER, schema enforcement, Change Data Feed)
- Spark SQL and the PySpark DataFrame API
- data-quality expectations
- Unity Catalog objects (catalogs, schemas, volumes, tags, masks)
- Lakeflow Jobs (task dependencies, retries, parameters)

Use the Q&A above as revision prompts. Auto Loader and Lakeflow Declarative Pipelines are described here but not implemented, so study them separately.

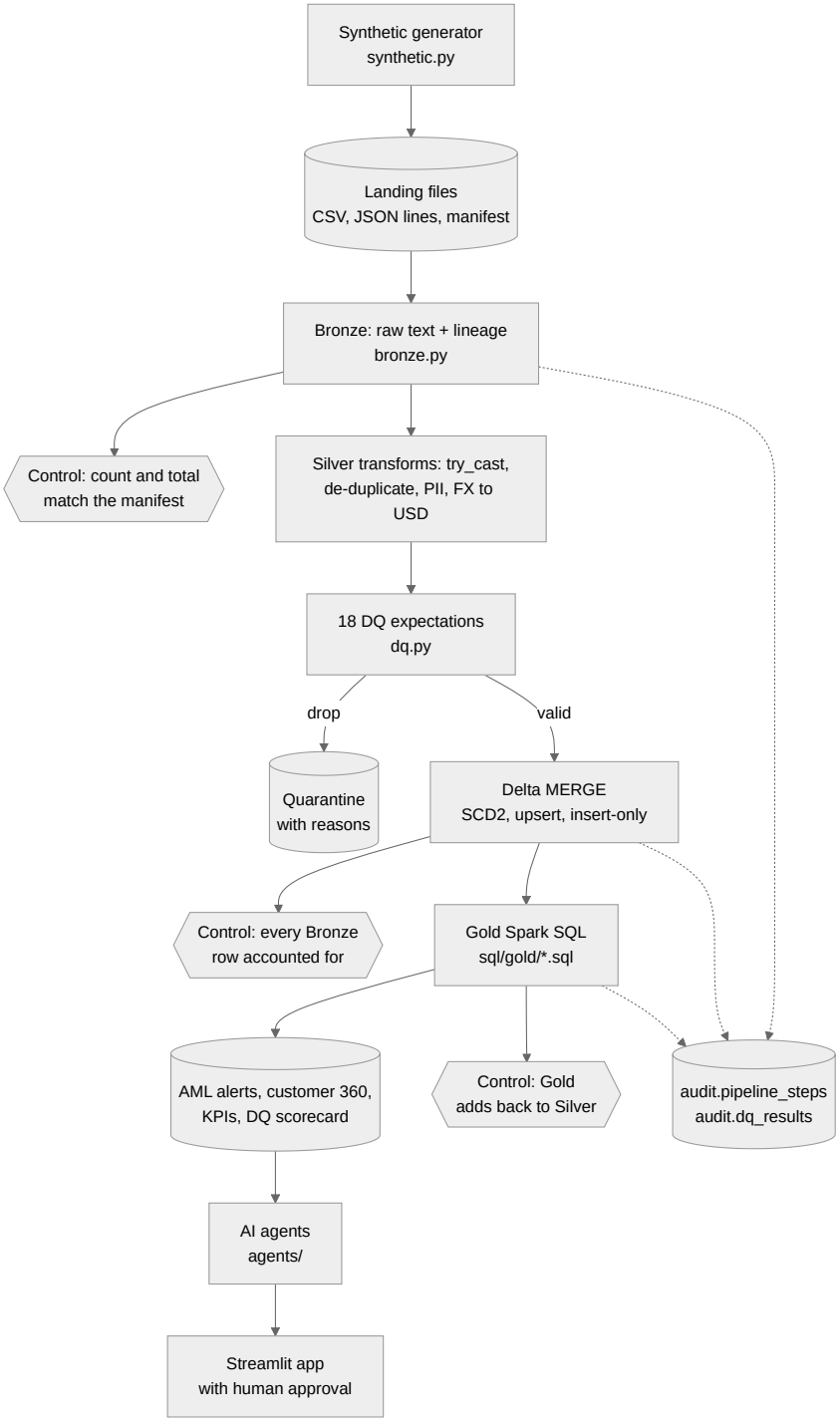
Appendix A · Architecture

1. Context

Banks run on data that arrives late, twice, or broken: a core-banking extract with a missing amount, a payment file re-sent after a timeout, a customer whose KYC risk rating changed overnight. Risk, finance and financial-crime teams still need numbers they can trust and trace back to source. This project builds that foundation for **Ledgerline Bank**, a fictional bank. It is a lakehouse that lands source files, validates and conforms them, keeps full history, and publishes business-ready tables with evidence that nothing was lost or double-counted. Three AI agents then work on top of those tables, the way an analyst would: investigating AML alerts, explaining a blocked load and answering business questions. A person approves everything they propose.

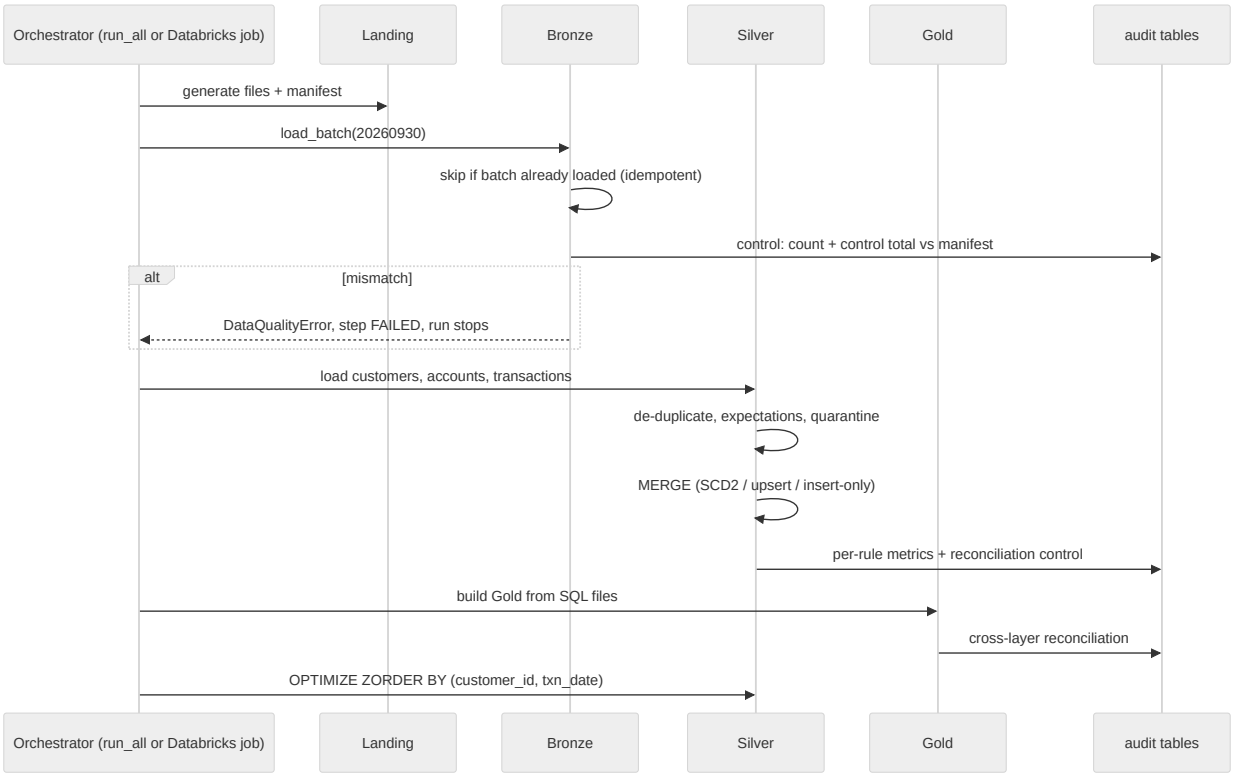
All data is synthetic, generated from a fixed seed. No real bank, customer or employer data is used.

2. Component view



The `TableStore` class (`lakehouse/store.py`) is the only code that knows where a table lives. Locally a table is a Delta folder, referenced as `delta.`…/silver/transactions``. On Databricks it is a Unity Catalog table, `workspace.ledgerline_silver.transactions`. Everything else is identical, so the code that runs in CI is the code that runs on Databricks.

3. Run flow (one batch)



On Databricks, `databricks/01_create_job.py` creates the same flow as a **Lakeflow Jobs** DAG: `land → reference → batch_20260930 → batch_20261007 → gold → optimize`. All tasks share one `run_id`, so the audit tables read the same way as a local run.

4. Data model

Layer	Table	Grain	Key points
Bronze	`customers`, `accounts`, `transactions`	one row per delivered record	Strings only, append-only, lineage columns
Bronze	`ref_fx_rates`, `ref_country_risk`, `ref_branches`	one row per reference record	Full refresh
Silver	`customers`	one row per customer **version**	SCD Type 2: `effective_from`, `effective_to`, `is_current`, `record_hash`. E-mail stored as SHA-256, phone masked. Invalid KYC rating defaults to HIGH (fail-safe)
Silver	`accounts`	one row per account	SCD Type 1 upsert on status, product and limit changes
Silver	`transactions`	one row per `txn_id`	Typed amounts, `amount_usd` at the daily FX rate, direction, counterparty risk tier, `dq_warnings`
Silver	`*_quarantine`	one row per rejected record	Raw values kept, plus `_dq_failed_rules`
Gold	`aml_alert_candidates`	one row per alert	Rule, rationale, transaction ids, priority, always `PENDING_REVIEW`

Layer	Table	Grain	Key points
Gold	`customer_360`	one row per current customer	Profile, holdings, 30-day activity, alerts. No names or contact details
Gold	`daily_transaction_summary`	date × type × channel × direction	Counts and USD totals
Gold	`segment_monthly_kpis`	month × segment	Joins transactions to the customer version valid **on the transaction date**
Gold	`dq_scorecard`	rule × table for the latest run	Rows checked, failed, pass rate, status
Audit	`pipeline_steps`, `dq_results`	one row per step/table, per rule	Run log and DQ evidence for every run

5. Data-quality rules and controls

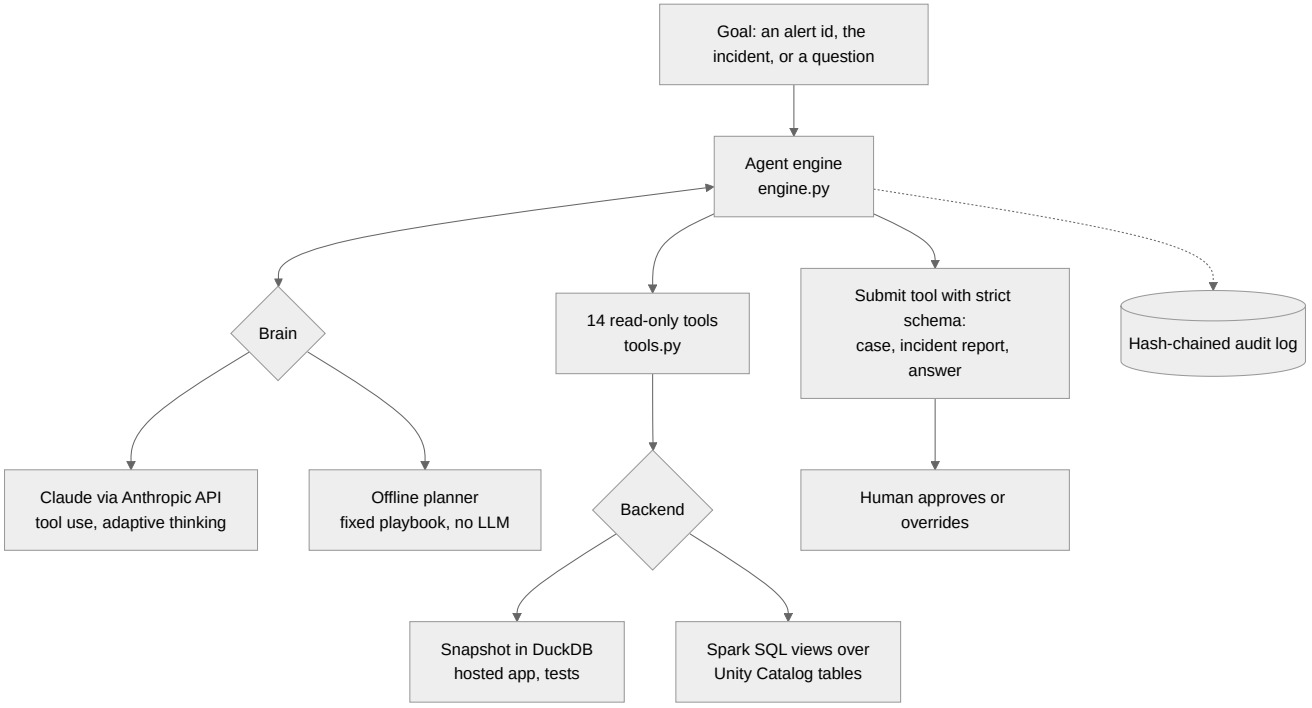
Table	Rule	Action
customers	`customer_id_present`, `valid_segment`	drop
customers	`valid_risk_rating` (defaults to HIGH), `valid_email`, `dob_present`, `known_country`	warn
accounts	`account_id_present`, `known_customer`, `valid_currency`, `valid_status`	drop
transactions	`txn_id_present`, `amount_present`, `amount_positive`, `valid_currency`, `valid_timestamp`, `not_future_dated`, `known_account`, `fx_rate_available`	drop

Blocking controls (action `fail`) stop the run and log the step as FAILED:

1. Bronze row count equals the source manifest, per file and batch.
2. The Bronze amount total equals the manifest control total.
3. Silver reconciliation per entity: Bronze = duplicates + quarantined + valid, and for transactions, valid = inserted + already loaded.
4. The Gold daily summary adds back to Silver in count and USD value.
5. Gold segment KPIs cover every Silver transaction, which proves the SCD2 as-of join is complete.

In the committed run, every planted defect was caught and nothing else was quarantined. That gives 25 rows quarantined and 33 duplicates removed. 16 of the 17 blocking controls passed. The 17th tripped on purpose: delivery 20261014 is planted with a truncated `transactions.jsonl` (the manifest says 3,150 rows; 2,835 complete rows and one cut-off line arrived). The Bronze count control blocked it, and the Delta versions of Silver and Gold before and after are identical, which the tests check.

6. AI agents



Agent	Tools	Output
AML Investigator	`get_alert`, `get_transactions`, `get_customer_profile`, `get_customer_activity`, `compare_to_peers`, `find_counterparty_history`, `counterparty_network`, `run_sql`	`submit_case`: ESCALATE or CLOSE, risk score 0-100, red flags, mitigating factors, evidence transaction ids, narrative, next steps
Data Steward	`get_pipeline_status`, `get_dq_findings`, `inspect_delivery`, `get_delivery_history`, `run_sql`	`submit_incident_report`: root-cause category, rows expected, received and missing, downstream impact, remediation, draft ticket
Ask Ledgerline	`list_tables`, `run_sql`	`submit_answer`: answer, final SQL, chart spec

- **Same tools, two brains.** `ClaudeBrain` runs a manual tool-use loop with the Anthropic SDK. Tool errors (for example a SQL typo) go back to the model as `is_error` results so it can correct itself, and prompt caching keeps the growing conversation cheap. `ScriptedBrain` drives the same tools from a Python playbook, so the hosted app works with no key, and the evaluation has a baseline.
- **Guardrails.** Tools only read. SQL must be a single read-only statement, and results are capped at 1,000 rows. Ids are validated by pattern before they reach a query. Each agent has a tool-call limit. Tool results are truncated before going back to the model. The recording script stops at a dollar cap.
- **Human in the loop.** Agents only recommend. On Databricks, case reports land with `review_status = PENDING_HUMAN_REVIEW`; in the app, approve and override are written to the audit log.
- **Evaluation.** `agents/evals.py` scores every output against the generator's answer key (`run_summary.json -> planted`), which the agents' tools cannot read. Checks include the right decision (7 alerts should escalate; the planted payroll false positive for C000212 should close), trigger transactions cited, no invented transaction ids, score consistent with decision, no contact data in narratives, the correct incident row counts, and SQL that returns the same result as a reference query.
- **Recorded runs.** `run_agents.py --brain claude --record` saves every Claude run (thoughts, tool calls, tokens, cost) to `data/agent_runs/`. The hosted app replays them, so visitors see exactly what Claude did without the app calling the API.

- **On Databricks.** `databricks/03_ai_agents.py` runs the agents over Spark SQL views of the Unity Catalog tables and appends to `gold.aml_case_reports` and `audit.agent_steps`.

7. Delta Lake features used

Feature	Where	Why it matters in a bank
ACID MERGE	`silver.py`	A batch is applied completely or not at all, so readers never see half a load
SCD Type 2 via MERGE	`load_customers`	You can answer "what was this customer's rating when the payment happened?"
Insert-only MERGE	`load_transactions`	A re-sent payment file cannot double-count money
Time travel (`VERSION AS OF`)	tests, app	Reproduce a report exactly as it was, for audit or incident review
Change Data Feed	Silver tables	Downstream systems consume only what changed
Schema enforcement	test	A bad upstream change fails loudly instead of corrupting a table
OPTIMIZE + Z-ORDER	`pipeline.optimize`	Fewer, better-organised files, so investigator queries skip irrelevant data
`_metadata.file_path`	`bronze.py`	Row-level lineage back to the delivered file

8. Security and privacy

- Synthetic data only. High-risk jurisdictions use fictional ISO user-assigned codes (XR, XS, XE), so the data makes no claims about real countries.
- PII minimisation by layer. Bronze keeps the raw delivery, as a restricted evidence copy. Silver stores a hashed e-mail and a masked phone. Gold has no names, e-mail, phone or full date of birth.
- On Databricks, `02_unity_catalog_governance.sql` adds column comments, `classification = pii` tags and a column mask that shows names only to members of a KYC analyst group.
- The app's SQL console is DuckDB in memory with `enable_external_access = false` and the configuration locked. It accepts read-only statements and returns at most 1,000 rows. Tests prove that file reads, COPY, DROP, INSTALL and configuration changes are all blocked.
- There are no credentials in the code. Databricks notebooks authenticate as the signed-in user. The Anthropic API key, when used, comes from an environment variable, Streamlit secrets or a Databricks secret scope.
- Agents see Silver and Gold only, through read-only tools. Gold has no names or contact details, and the evaluation fails any narrative that contains an e-mail address or phone number.

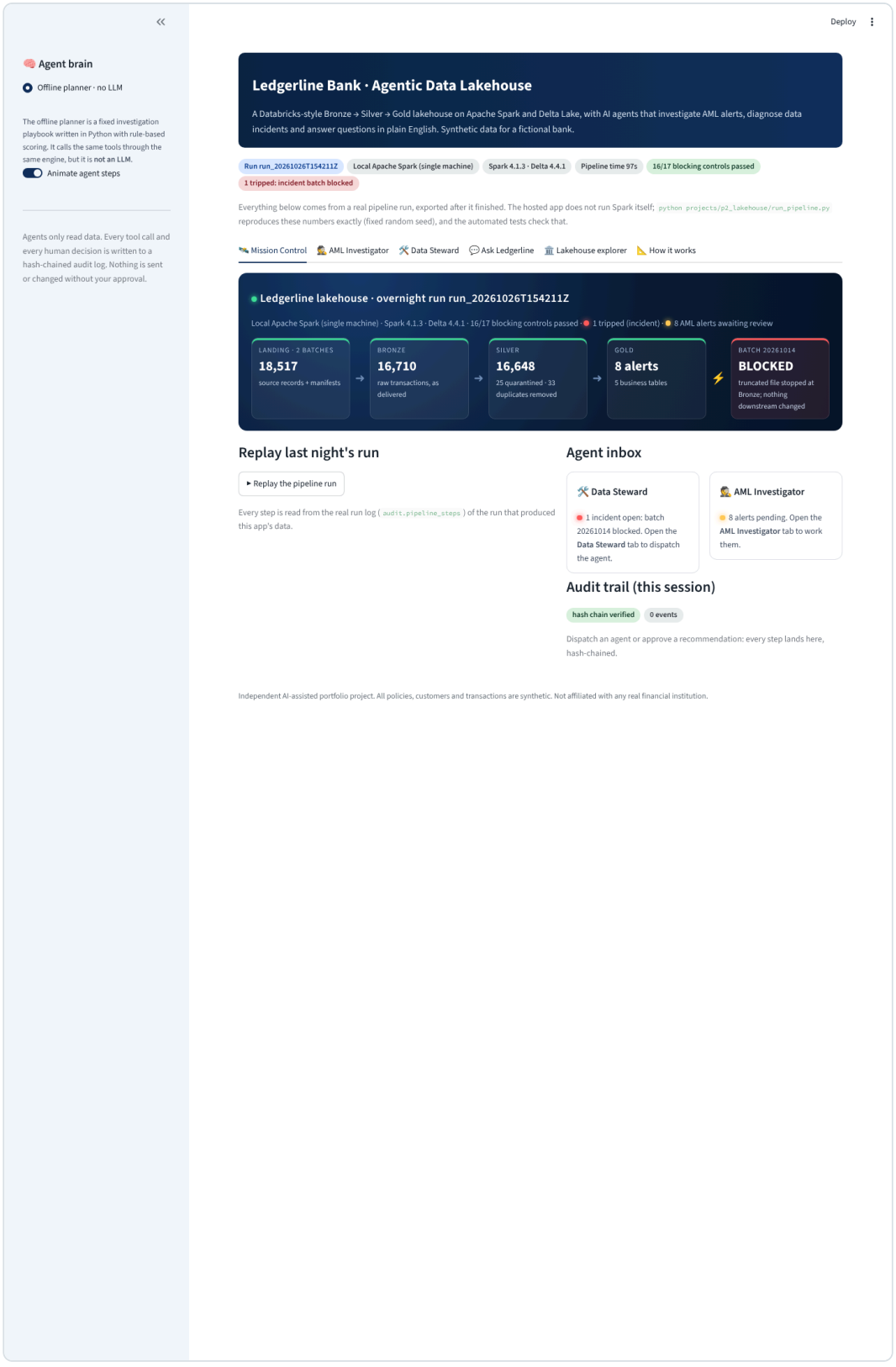
9. Cost

Item	Cost
Local / CI runs (GitHub Actions)	$0
Streamlit Community Cloud hosting	$0
Databricks Free Edition (serverless, quota-limited)	$0
Claude API (optional)	$0 by default: the hosted app replays recordings or uses the offline planner. A full recorded evaluation (16 runs) is capped at $5 and only runs with the owner's approval

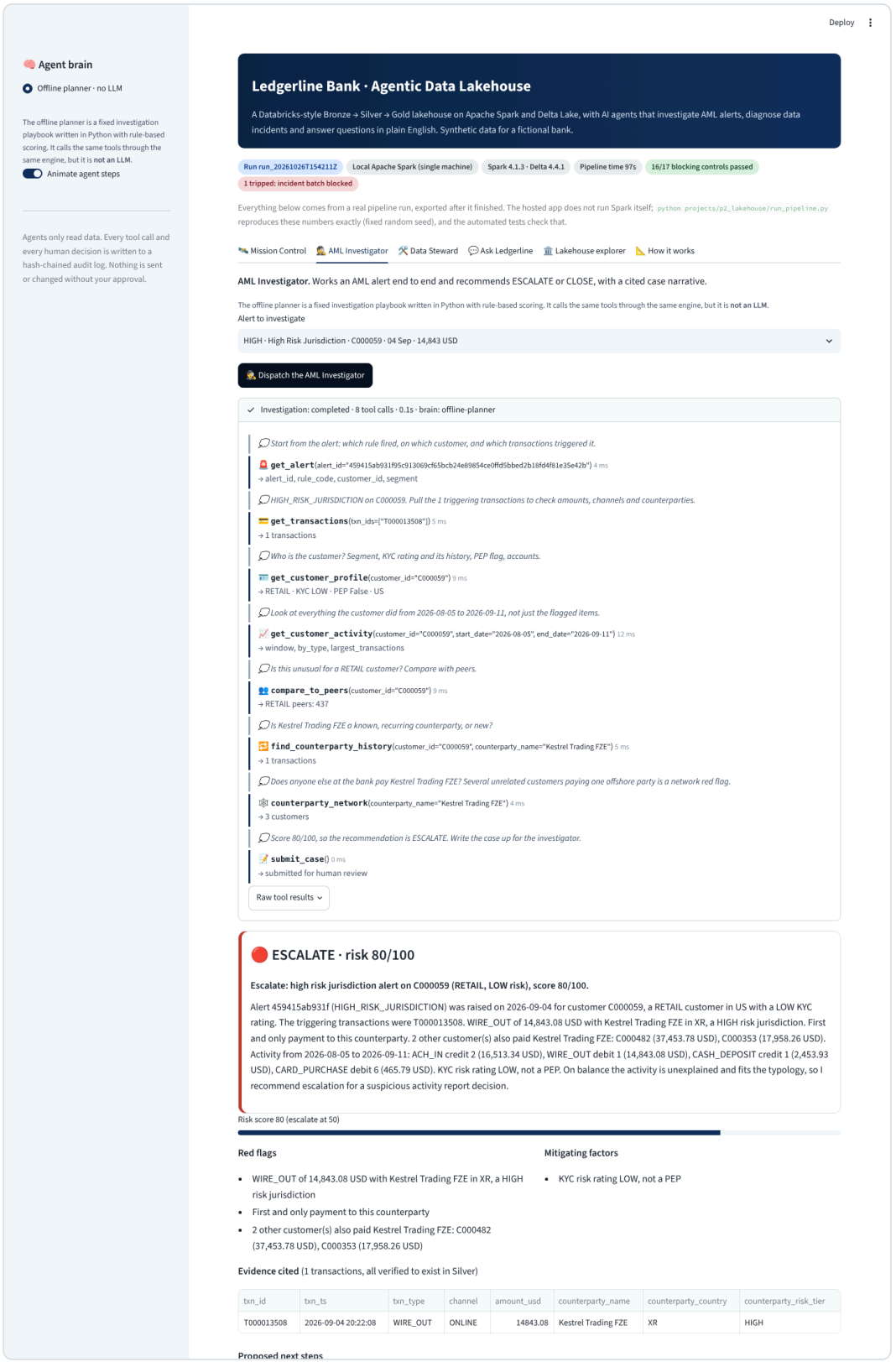
10. Trade-offs and limitations

- **The app shows a snapshot.** Community Cloud has no Java or Spark, so the app reads CSV/JSON exported from a real run. The run id, engine and versions are shown in the header, and a test checks that a fresh run reproduces the snapshot exactly.
- **Batch, not streaming.** The landing zone is read with batch reads. On Databricks the natural next step is Auto Loader (`cloudFiles`) with `availableNow` triggers, or Lakeflow Declarative Pipelines, whose expectations map one-to-one onto `dq.py` rules.
- **Gold is fully recomputed** on each run. That is fine at this scale. At bank scale, Gold would read the Silver Change Data Feed incrementally.
- **AML rules are simple and illustrative.** They are thresholds, not a model, and are not regulatory guidance. They produce candidates for a human investigator and never decisions.
- **The offline planner is not AI.** It is a fixed playbook with rule-based scoring, there so the app works for free and the evaluation has a baseline. The app labels it everywhere it appears. Claude's own scores appear only after a real recorded run.
- **The agents' evaluation is small.** It has 8 alerts, 1 incident and 6 questions. It catches regressions and hallucinated evidence, but it is not a statistically meaningful benchmark.
- **Single-machine Spark locally.** Performance numbers are not representative of a cluster.
- **Databricks: notebook run verified, job and governance not yet.** On 2026-10-26, Nipun ran `00_run_pipeline` on Databricks Free Edition (serverless, Spark 4.2.0, Unity Catalog, run `run_20261026T144959Z`, 356 s). Every table count matched the local run of that data version exactly (see `docs/evidence/databricks_run_20261026.png`). The newer data version and the agents notebook (`03_ai_agents`, free Foundation Model endpoint) were then run on Free Edition too, reported done by Nipun on 2026-10-26 (no screenshot; which free model was used and its scores were not captured). The 6-task Lakeflow job (`01_create_job`) and the column masks and tags (`02_unity_catalog_governance.sql`) have not been run yet.

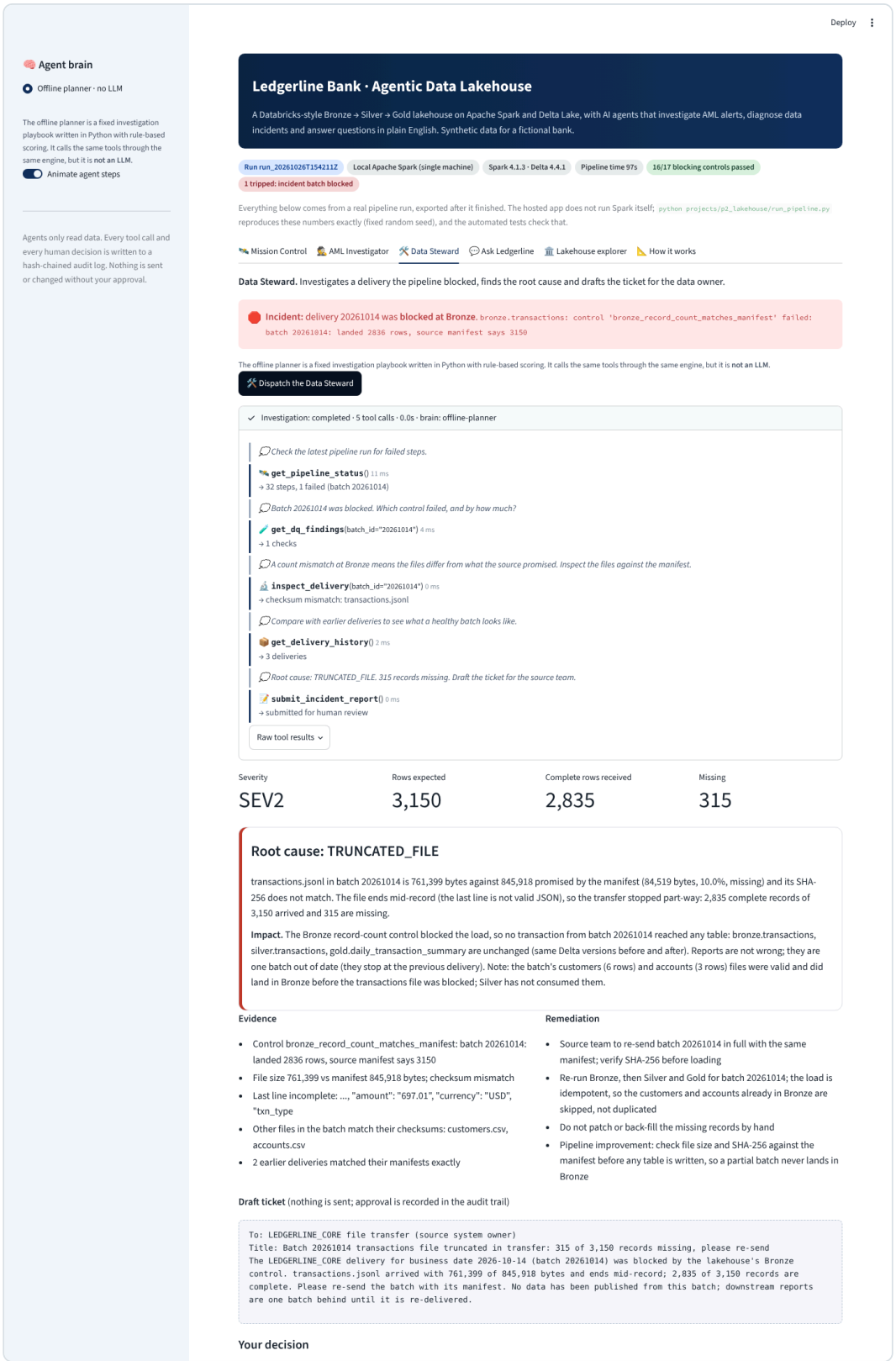
Appendix B · Screenshots from the automated browser test



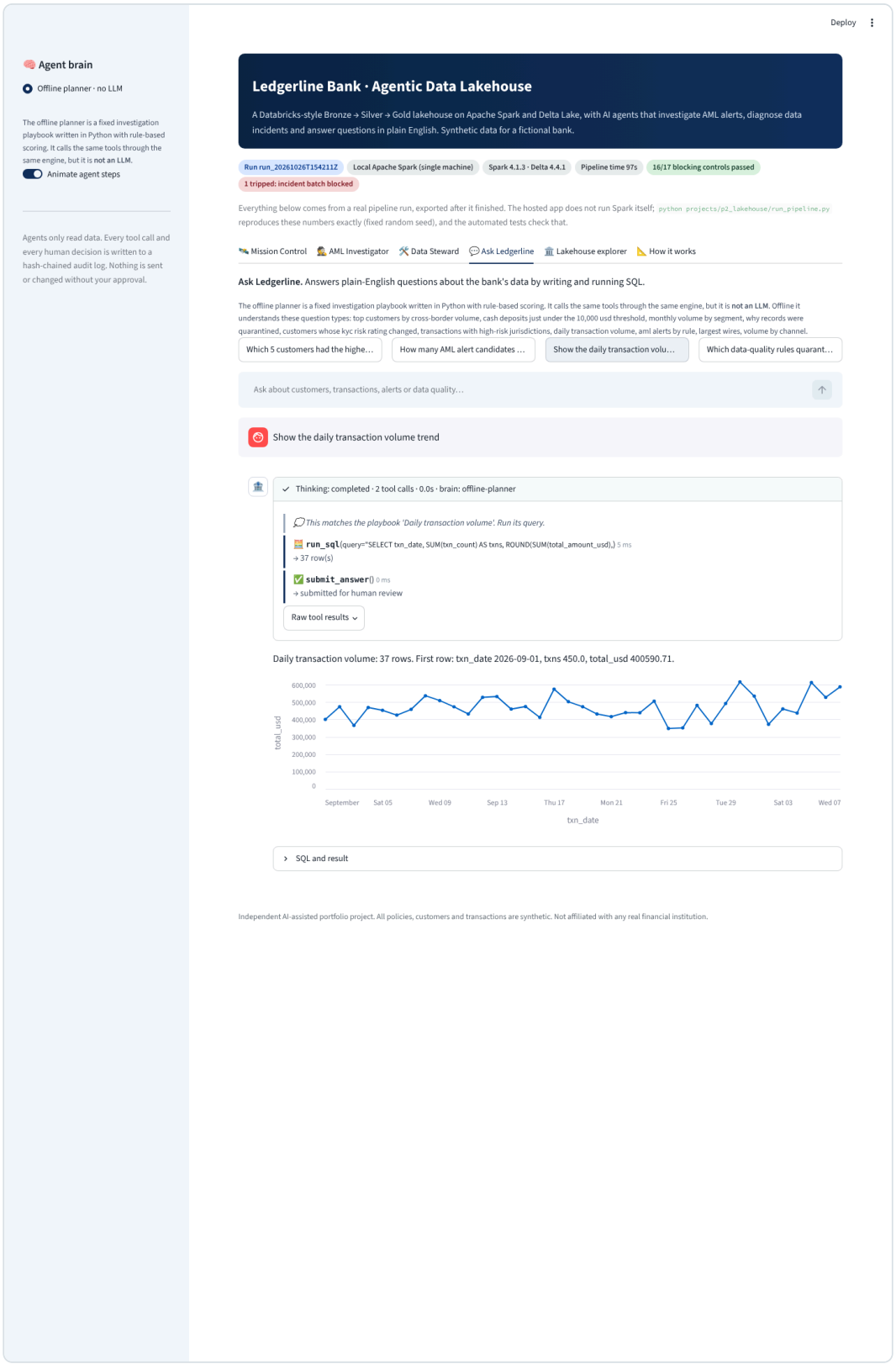
Mission Control: overnight run, the blocked delivery and the agent inbox



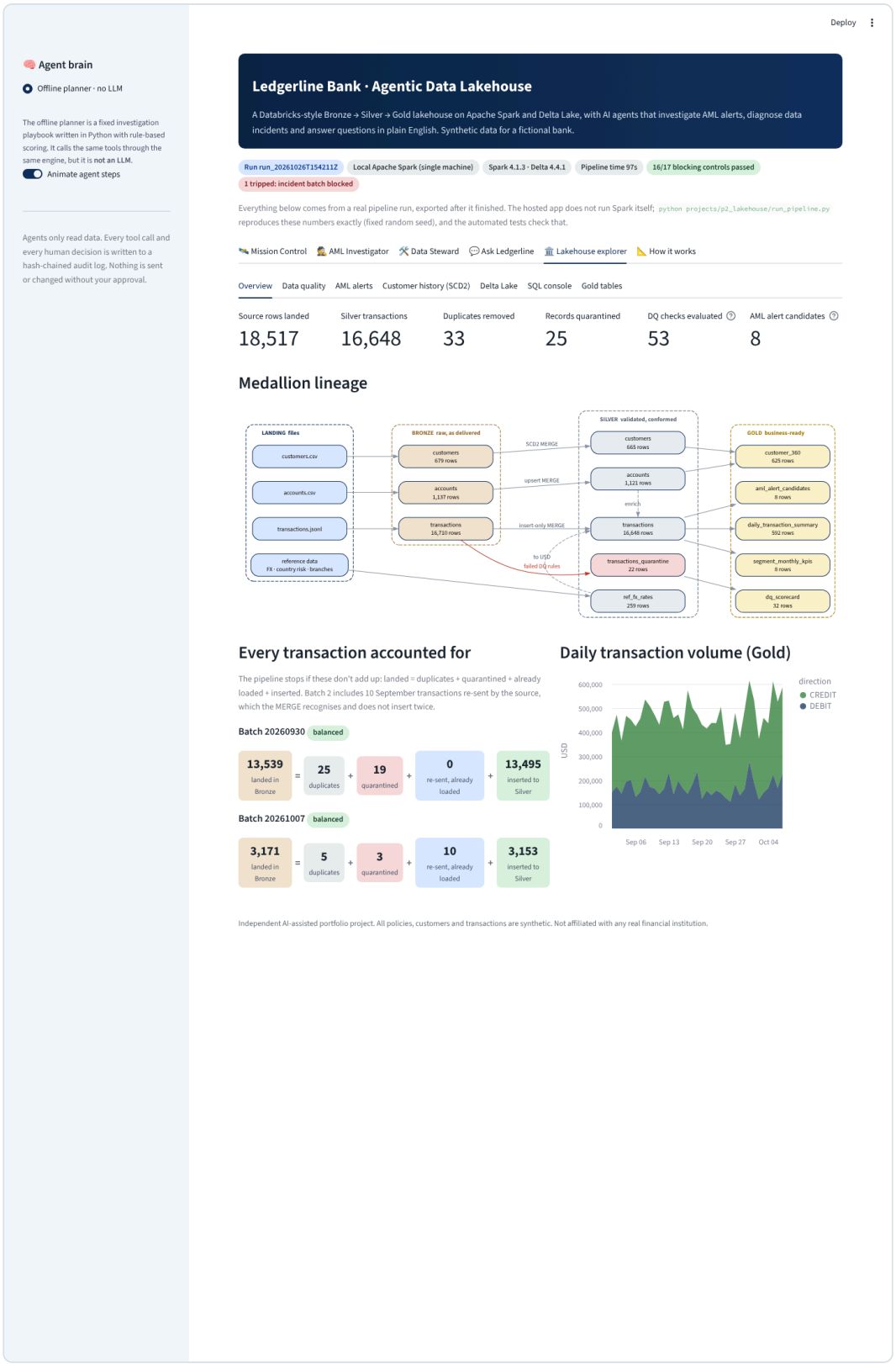
AML Investigator: agent trace, scored case with cited evidence, human decision



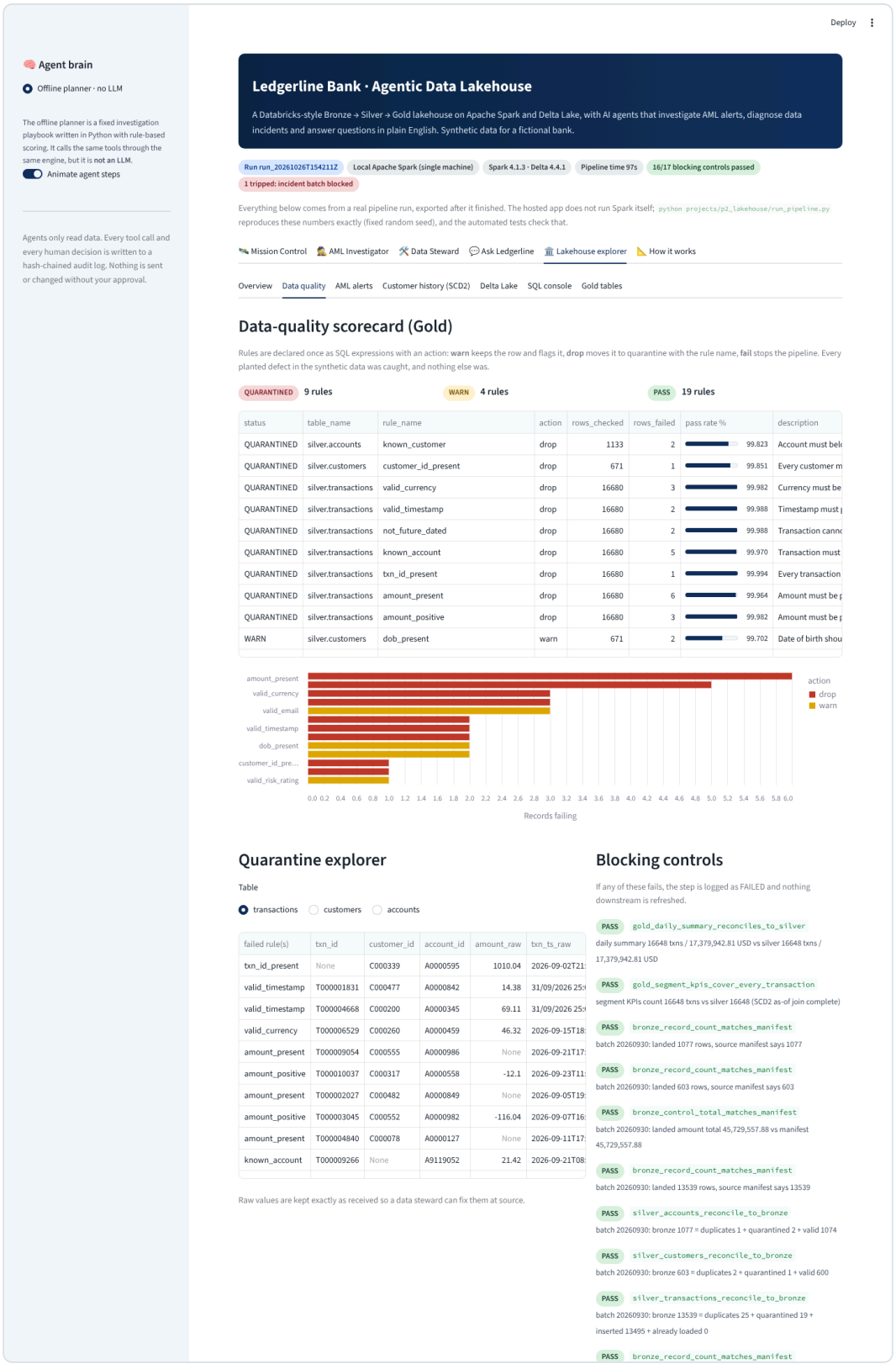
Data Steward: root cause of the blocked delivery and a draft ticket



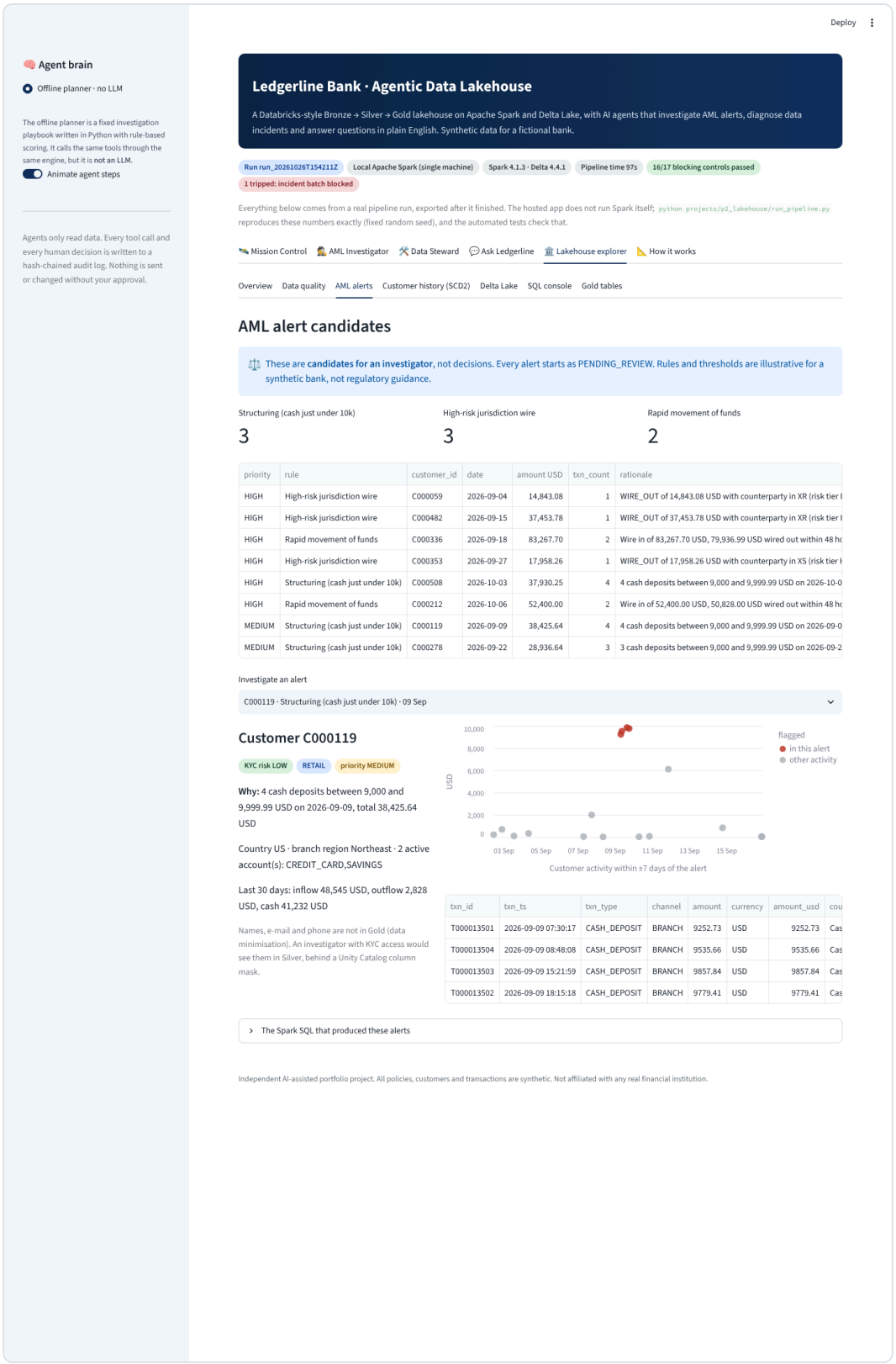
Ask Ledgerline: plain-English question answered with SQL and a chart



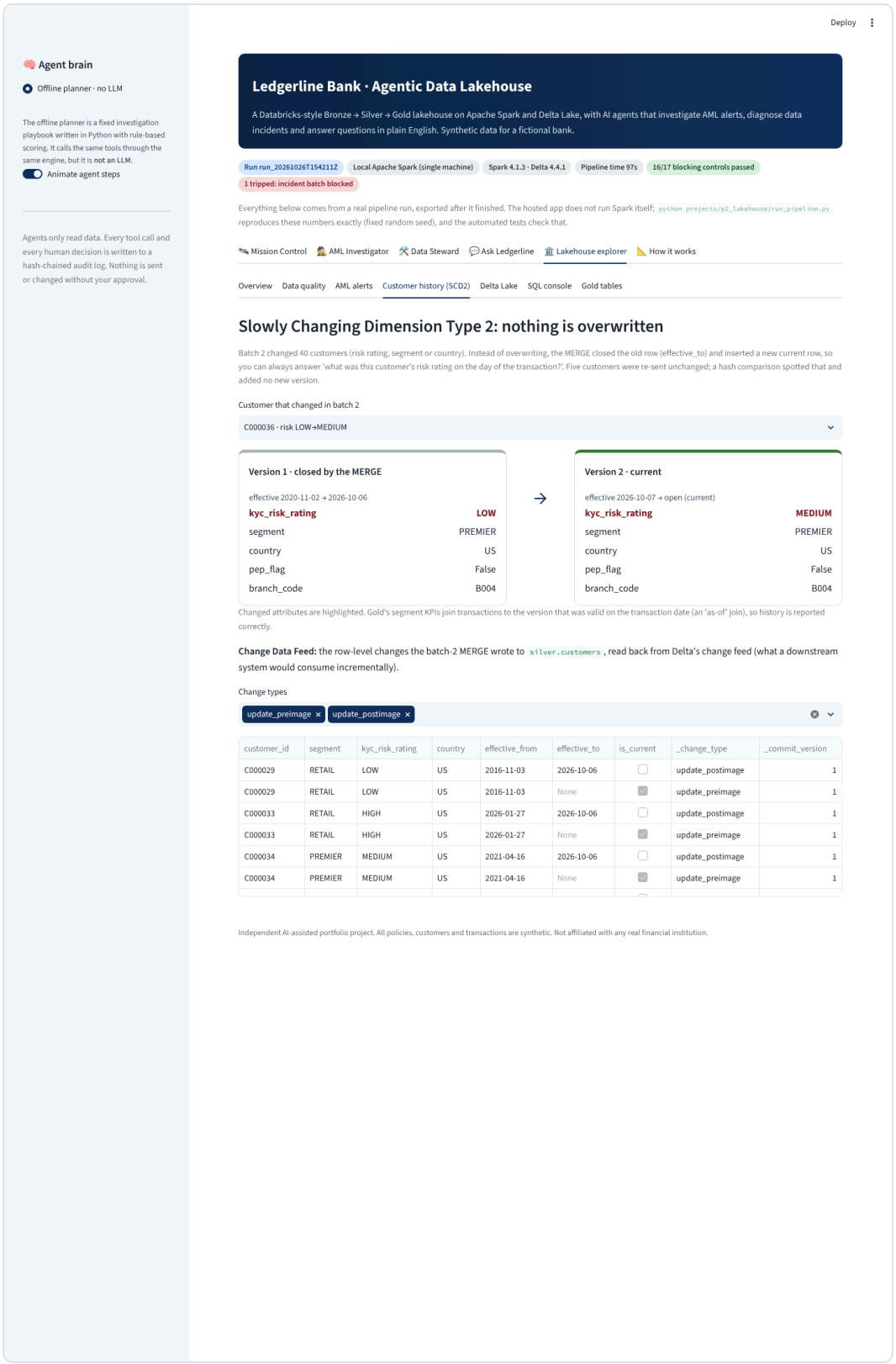
Overview: run badge, medallion lineage with row counts, reconciliation



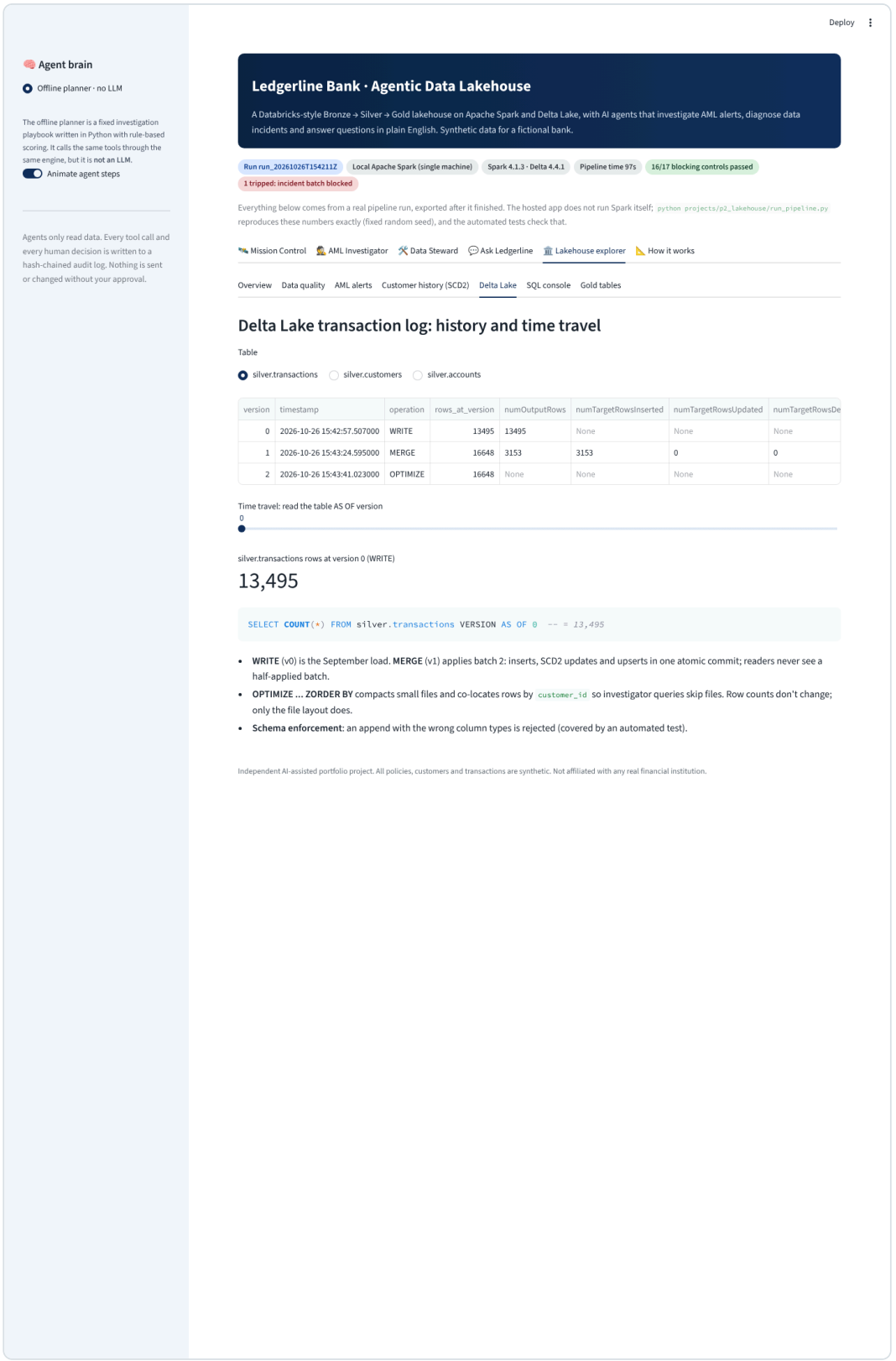
Data quality: scorecard, quarantine explorer, blocking controls



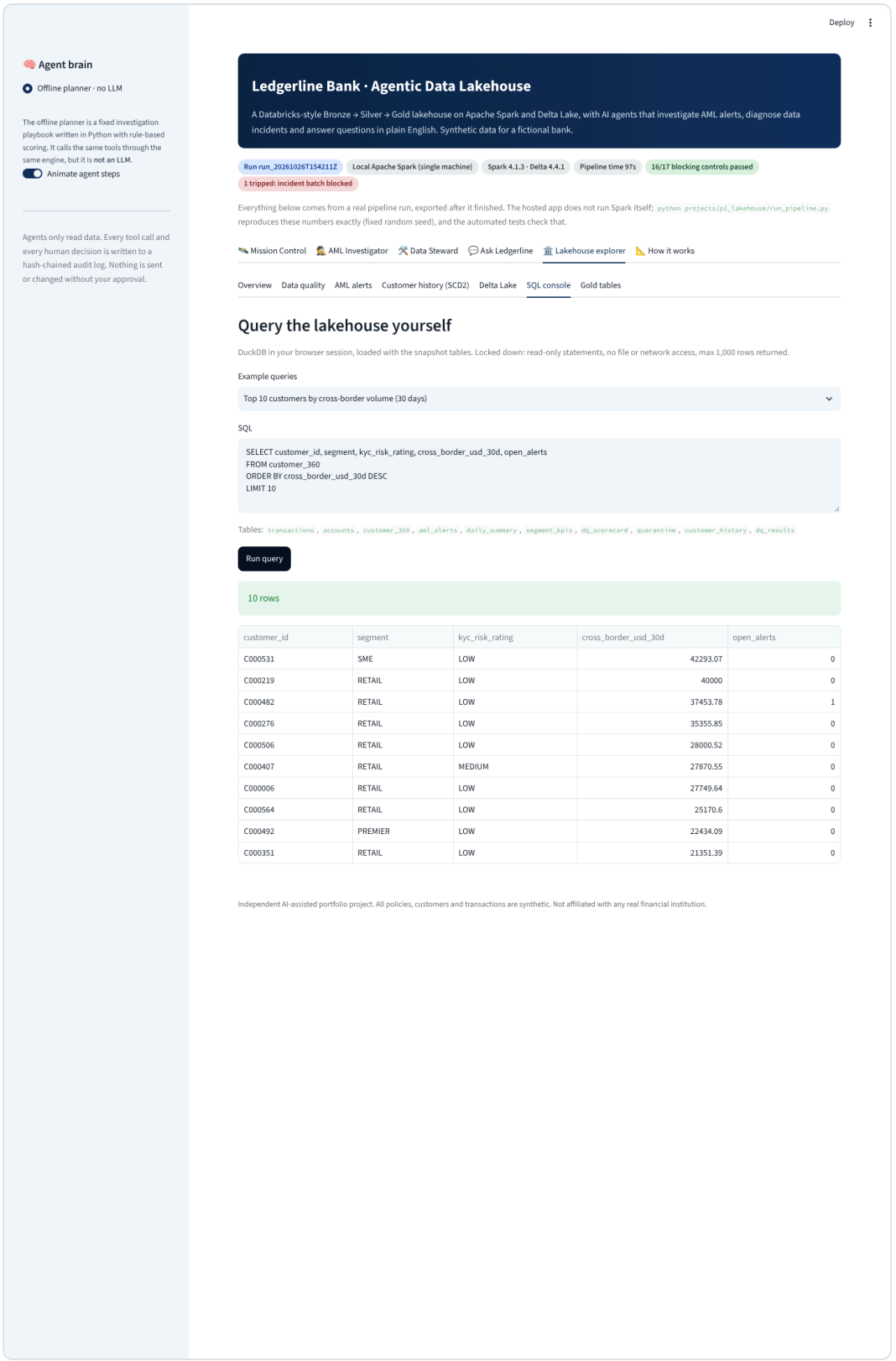
AML alert drill-down: rationale, customer profile, transactions in context



SCD Type 2 before/after and Change Data Feed



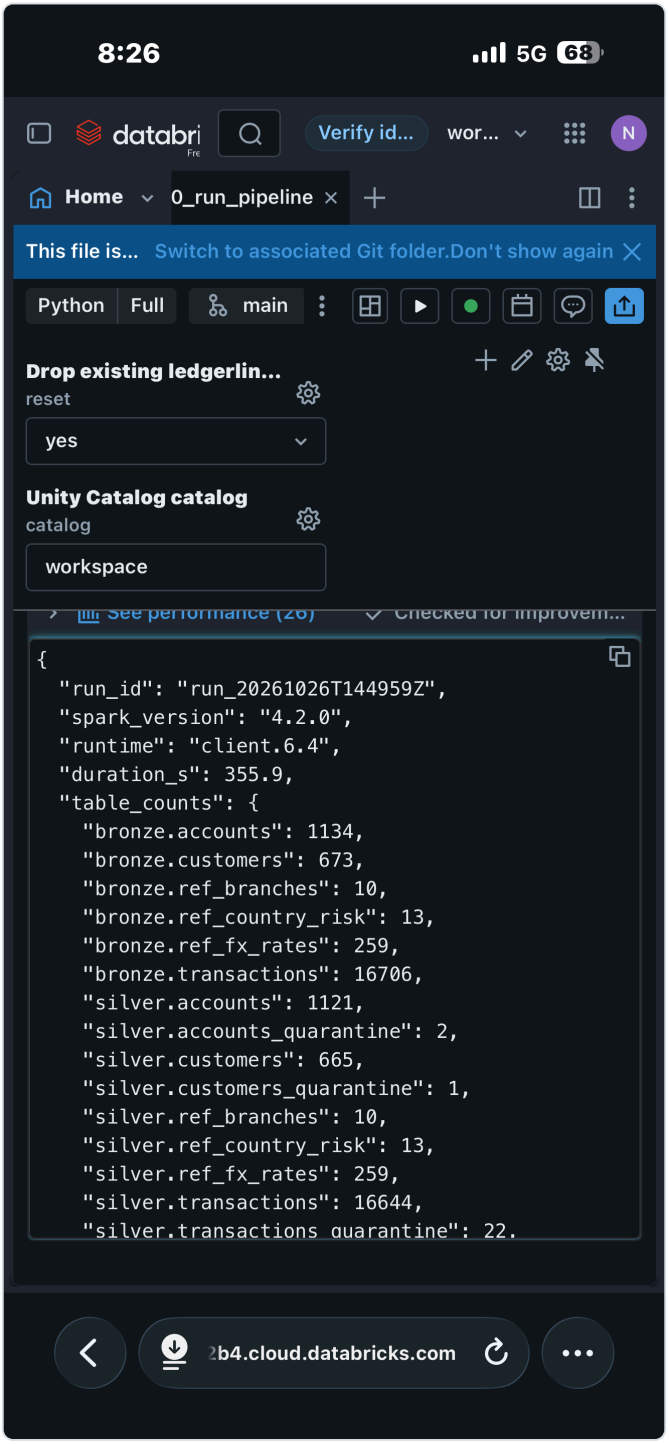
Delta history and time travel



Sandboxed SQL console

Appendix C · Databricks Free Edition run (26 October 2026)

Run `run_20261026T144959Z` of the `00_run_pipeline` notebook on serverless compute (Spark 4.2.0, Unity Catalog). It finished in 356 seconds. Bronze, Silver and quarantine counts are identical to the local run of that data version (before the incident batch and payroll false positive were added): 16,706 Bronze transactions, 16,644 Silver transactions, and 22 + 1 + 2 quarantined. Screenshot taken by the author.



Final notebook cell: run summary and table counts